Of Miscommunications and Mistletoes

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Of Miscommunications and Mistletoes

by ResFlower

Summary

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Catra quietly does as she's asked, wincing as she elevates her leg. Then she looks at Adora, unclear what will happen now. She has a plan but now it feels silly in the face of how clearly upset Adora is. She's not sure what else she expected.

"Catra, why are you here?" Adora's arms are crossed over her chest, and she looks anything but happy to see her.

Catra feels her gut drop to her toes under Adora's searching gaze. "Surprised to see me?"

Adora scoffs angrily. "Yeah, I don't expect my ex-girlfriend to just show up out of the blue in the middle of a snowstorm."

It's a good thing that Adora turns around in that moment because Catra has no idea what her face looks like.

Ex-girlfriend?

OR

Catra and Adora make up after getting stuck in a cabin on a snowy mountain. Solstice Swap 2024!

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra hopes this isn't Glimmer's idea of a prank because she might end up dead. The climb is steep and slippery. She has to think more than once where she can put her feet, lest she falls off the side of this fucking mountain. She is so fucking tired and *cold*, the wind unforgiving as she walks the last way up to where she thinks Razz's cabin is.

Well, Adora's cabin now that Razz is gone. She's a little surprised that Adora made her way up here—she figured that Adora would be with Glimmer for the holidays. It's why she went straight to Glimmer's house after realizing that Adora wasn't in her apartment. She'd been worried Adora would take another job before they could sort things out between them.

After their fight—the worst one they'd had in two years of dating—Adora left for the hospital a good five hours away. Given her schedule, Catra knew she'd be away for at least ten days.

Catra didn't have the nerve to reach out to Adora at first because of how explosive their fight was. She feels shame at how she'd stormed off, unable to keep a grip on her emotions.

She was angry, so angry that her whole body vibrated with the need to tear Adora apart with her words. Instead of doing that, she'd walked away, telling Adora in no uncertain terms that she was unequipped to deal with this. With them. Now she's built-up nerves in spades, ready to reach out. Time has gone by and now it's been over three weeks since they'd spoken and Catra just *misses* Adora.

She misses waking up to Adora's light snores and her warm arm tossed over Catra's torso. She misses their quiet conversations after work or the more animated way Adora would tell stories over dinner. She even misses Adora's overly energetic Pomeranian, although she'd never admit to that part.

So here she is, trying to find this fucking cabin up on a mountain so that she can make up with her girlfriend. The only trouble is that the path is too steep and narrow for Catra to attempt with her car, not with the snow falling like a curtain over the mountain tops. She should have checked the weather before she got in her car, but she was too busy with her other thoughts.

She'd never been to Razz's cabin, but Adora talks about it all the time, when she used to come up here with her family growing up. She'd promised Catra she would bring her sometime, but between work and life there was never a good opportunity. Maybe it'll be a full circle moment, to discuss things in a place that means so much to Adora—that they'd been meaning to see together anyway.

She thinks she finally sees the cabin—a cluster of them, really, on the highest point on this mountain—when she loses her footing and falls. She hears her ankle crack before she feels the pain shooting up her leg. She lets out a short whimper, blood rushing down to the area making it painful and hot.

Catra looks down at her foot in disappointment. "Fuck." She grumbles. She's close enough now that she could probably limp there, but she doesn't know if she can get up alone. "Help!"

She decides to yell, hoping someone from the nearby cabins can hear her and decides to take pity.

She can feel the wetness from the snow seeping into her pants, making her legs and ass fall numb. She needs to get out of this soon. A tendril of true worry shoots up her spine as she realizes the short walk she thought she was going on has just become a dangerous trek.

"Anyone! Please!' Catra yells as loud as she can before trying to get up. She loses her balance when she tries to put some weight on her bad ankle, sending her sprawling again. "Fuck me."

"Catra?" She hears a baffled and familiar voice. It makes her shut her eyes, embarrassment rolling through her. For a moment, she considers just letting the snow take her so she doesn't have to have Adora of all people find her here.

But the damage is done and Catra might as well be humiliated and warm if that's an option. She can't really see her girlfriend, just the silhouette of her firmly bundled, light flooding in behind her. She sighs and points down to her leg. "I fucked up my ankle coming up here. Think you can give me a hand?"

Adora stares at a moment, before she silently leans down and scoops Catra up in her arms. Her gait is sure and strong as she quickly brings Catra into a cabin on the far side of the cluster. Catra swallows thickly as she grabs onto Adora's shoulders for stability.

Even with a puffer jacket, Adora's body is warm and Catra just wants to curl into her. She'd missed her so much she can hardly believe they hadn't spoken in this long. She lets her head rest on Adora's shoulder, happy for the small reprieve of being close.

Catra's so distracted by just being in Adora's space she lets out a yelp when Adora unceremoniously drops her on the couch when she steps into the cabin. She pulls off her jacket and toes out of her boots, hanging the garment before turning to eye Catra.

"You're going to need dry clothes. You'll freeze in those." Adora says gruffly, before bending down. She grabs Catra's leg with surprising gentleness, softly pressing her fingers to the top of her ankle. She looks up at Catra, eyes guarded. "You really messed this up."

Catra can't tell if she's talking about her ankle or their relationship. "I know."

Adora grunts as she sits on the ground and pulls Catra's foot in her lap to examine it more closely. "It's probably not broken. We will need to ice it." It's a clinical observation, like Catra is a patient in one of the many hospitals Adora works for and not her girlfriend.

"It's fucking freezing out there." Catra thinks about making a crack about not needing ice when there's a blizzard outside, but the rest of her words stop short when Adora looks up at her, eyes almost vacant.

"It's the northern reach. Not sure what you expected," Adora's words are stiff and angry as she stands up from the ground before walks toward what Catra assumes is the bedroom. "I'm getting a first aid kit and a change of clothes. Stay right there."

Catra isn’t sure where Adora thinks she could go given her limited mobility. She sighs and looks around the cabin. It's small, probably one or two rooms if Catra had to guess. There are a few pictures on some bookshelves, but they are too far from the couch for Catra to make out the subjects. She guesses there are probably some of Adora, but it's not like she can ask about that right now.

She tries to keep breathing evenly as she realizes that she has no fucking clue what she's gotten herself into. Adora is still mad—that’s patently obvious from their brief interaction. It's not that Catra thought she wouldn't be, but she'd thought Adora would also feel as tired as she did of fighting. It seems like that isn't what's happened.

Before she can ponder it for too long, Adora is back. She sighs as she eyes Catra. "I'll help you to the bathroom so you can change first, then we can treat that ankle."

Catra wants to protest, to say the first thing they need to do is *actually* talk, but she's miserably cold and wet in her clothes. She nods timidly, letting Adora carry most of her body weight to the short walk to the bathroom. She hands over some clothes, clearing her throat uncomfortably.

"I'll be out here if you need anything." She quickly closes the door, leaving Catra staring at the grainy wood. Catra sighs, shaking her head. She'll find a way to fix this—but first she needs to change.

It takes forever to pull off her wet jeans as they cling to her, and even longer to take off her shoes, especially the one on her injured leg. She almost cries out when she manages to take it off because it feels like her ankle doubled in size instantaneously.

Catra also can't help but notice what clothes these are—it's Adora's sweatpants and an oversized t-shirt. It's incredibly warm and it smells so much like her Catra eyes water with as she buries her nose in the material. God, she's so pathetic, crying over a scrap of fabric. She quickly pulls it over her head and then knocks on the door, letting Adora know she's done.

Adora opens the door. Her eyes overlook Catra for a moment before eyeing her bare feet with disapproval. "You took off the shoe." She murmurs, eyes narrowed on the ground.

"I couldn't get the jeans off with them on." She defends. Catra has been around Adora long enough to know that it probably isn’t her best move to pull off her boot like that, but what else can she do?

Adora purses her lips and sighs before nodding. "Alright. We'll have to work quickly."

Catra hobbles toward the couch, feeling more uncomfortable by the minute. This was definitely a mistake.

Neither of them says anything as Adora frowns down at her ankle before wrapping it in a light compress. Even that feels tight though, as if her pulse is radiating out of her injury. The moment Adora is done she gets up and grabs an ice pack, wrapping it in a thin kitchen towel before pressing it to Catra's skin.

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Ex-girlfriend?

Catra watches Adora's back as she lets the words sink in, profound horror making its way into every inch of her chest. No way. That's not what happened, was it? She tries to retrace her steps, tries to find a moment she should have known it was over but she's at a loss.

When Adora turns back Catra doesn't even begin to know how to address this. "I rented a cabin nearby." Is the first lie that makes its way out of Catra's mouth. "I remembered Razz's cabin was out by here and I thought it might be a nice place."

Adora opens her mouth then closes it tightly before nodding, her head held at a jaunty angle. "Okay." She takes a deep breath, running her fingers through her hair. "That's fine. It's going to be storming for a while so why don't you just ... sit there for a bit and we will see if it clears up?"

Catra stares up at her. "I—yeah. Could we ... talk? While I'm here?" She doesn't want Adora to go and busy herself elsewhere, which is what it looked like Adora was planning.

Adora's face twitches, her gaze narrowing. "What do you want to talk about?"

"Why did you come to Razz's cabin?" It's a lesser concern but it seems like the easiest thing to start with.

"I missed it up here." Adora makes a face, the kind that tells Catra she wanted to say something else and thought better of it. "I had a week off, so I came."

Catra bites back the first comment that pops into her head—that maybe she could have used her time off sorting out their fight instead of hiding in the woods. Instead, she nods slowly.

"Cool." Catra hides a wince and looks down at her foot. She's never felt this much awkwardness around Adora in her life. Coming here unannounced was such a mistake. "I should go. I don't want to interrupt your time off."

She needs to get out of here and lick her wounds in peace. Wrap her head around the fact that Adora thinks it's over between them. Maybe she’s right about it.

Adora's brow furrows. "There's a snowstorm outside. How do you think you're going to get around?" Her voice pitches up, arms across her body. She’s wearing a sweater Catra bought her last winter.

"Well, what's the alternative? Just camp out on your couch until the snow clears?"

She rolls her eyes. "You're injured. I'm not gonna have you mess up your ankle anymore by sleeping on the couch. You can take the bed."

"You're a giant, you don't fit on the couch. Besides, I'm the one that intruded and—you know, I'll just keep looking for my cabin. I think it's nearby anyway." She might be risking hypothermia but it's better than making Adora uncomfortable. She hobbles to the door, tugging on the handle, only to find that it won't give.

She can hear Adora’s heavy steps behind her. "You can't go out there in this weather. Stop being so stubborn." She chides. "Besides, it's late and dark."

She tugs harder but it’s no use. Catra groans and releases the doorknob. "The door won't open."

"Back up?" Catra does as she asks, letting Adora try her hand at it. Adora leans her shoulder into the door, the handle jingling uselessly as she tries to jimmy it. "Fuck." She leans her head against the door frame. "Sometimes it gets stuck when it's too cold. It's probably iced over."

She feels panic clawing up her throat. "So, we're stuck here?"

"Don't sound too excited." Adora mutters bitterly, not bothering to turn around. "Either way it's too dangerous for you to go out there."

Catra holds the wall, careful not to put weight on her foot. There's no use in fighting with Adora about leaving if she can't even get out of this cabin.

She sighs, her body sagging. Catra can feel Adora’s arm touching her as they both stand in the entryway. "You're right." She admits.

Adora's eyes widen in surprise, and she takes a step back, likely noticing how close they were standing huddled by the door. "Are you hungry?"

"No, I'm fine." Catra's stomach is in knots, she doubts she can hold down anything right now. "What do you usually do when you’re here?"

Adora chews on the corner of her bottom lip. Normally, Catra would reach her finger out and touch it lightly, reminding Adora of what she's doing. She doesn't do that now.

"Usually isn't really... I've only been here two days." She glances around helplessly. "There's books and music from when we used the cabin more."

"You've been reading?" It's not unlike Adora to read, but it usually takes a lot of interest for her to start a new book.

“No, I haven’t.” Adora helps her back to the couch. “How have you been?” Her voice is stiff and her gaze averted.

She thinks about being honest about how absolutely shitty the last few weeks have been, but instead she shrugs. “I’ve been better.”

She can see Adora’s throat bob as she swallows, her hands held tightly together. “I’m going to have something to eat. Help yourself to whatever you want.” It’s a quick mumble before she walks quickly out of the room. Although she doesn’t run, it feels like running to Catra.

She lets herself sink into the leather couch, her gut sinking right along with the rest of her. She’s making Adora uncomfortable—clearly, she wants nothing to do with Catra anymore. She can feel her eyes stinging with tears, her chest mangled and in pain. She can hear Adora puttering about in the kitchen, and she hopes it’s loud enough to cover Catra’s quiet sniffles. She dries her eyes quickly, trying to keep the tears at bay.

Adora stays away for well over an hour and Catra spends the time alternating between overthinking the last month of her life and letting herself cry about the startling reality that hasn’t fully sunk in yet. Catra knows she isn’t easy to love and some part of her always thought she’d lose Adora, but she thought she’d know when it happened—she didn’t expect to be blindsided with it.

When Adora pads back into the room, her eyes look red. Catra bites her lip as she realizes they were probably doing the same thing. “I’m kind of tired. Let me get you set up in the bedroom so I can fix up the couch for me.”

“I’m not sleeping there.” There’s zero chance she’ll kick Adora out of her bed or be engulfed in her smell as she tries to sleep. She’s not sure she’ll ever stop crying under those circumstances. “Just bring me a blanket and I’ll be okay there.”

Adora’s face twitches with irritation. “Your ankle needs to be elevated and this couch is too small. You can make your injury worse, and I won’t stand for that.”

“Because you’re a nurse?”

Adora’s eyes widen at the dig before her jaw clenches. “Something like that.” She turns on her heel. “I’ll be back with blankets and you’re going to the bedroom.”

Catra hates the way she says it, like a princess issuing a royal decree. When Adora thinks she knows best, she gets up on her high horse and there’s seldom a way to get her down. Normally, between whispers and kisses, Catra’s able to come to some common ground between them. Common ground on this feels impossible now.

It takes Adora way longer than the few minutes it should have to grab some blankets. Catra sits up, letting her foot drop onto the ground. She hisses, the area plenty tender. She ignores it

for now, her eyes scanning the room until she locks in on the hallway Adora went down. What was she doing that could take so long?

Almost as if called by thought, Adora comes back with a sheepish look on her face. “I don’t know what happened, but I can’t find any of the blankets in this house except for the ones on the bed.” She walks closer and Catra notices she’s changed into sleepwear—a soft pair of sweatpants and an oversized shirt Catra frequently stole when she stayed overnight with her. “I run warm though, so I can still take the couch.”

Catra’s about to protest again when there’s a loud hissing and pop and then a concerning silence. The heater had been on the whole time since she arrived, so she hadn’t really noticed the noise, but now that it’s stopped the silence is sharp and pointed. She can see Adora coming to the same realization at the same time, eyes pivoting to the far wall.

“Fuck.” She curses, moving toward the radiator. Adora crouches down to look at the metal tubes. “I think the radiator is broken.”

She raises an eyebrow. “I gathered.” Already the pleasant warmth is seeping out of the walls, the cold leeching in. The cabin is going to be frigid soon. “We’re going to have to share the bed.”

Adora is still crouched down in front of the radiator, shoulders slumped over. “Yeah.” She stands up turning back to Catra. “Let’s go bundle up. We need to figure out how to prop up your leg.”

Catra is numb when she walks into the small bedroom, holding the wall for support. She notices Adora’s hand twitch at her side, but she doesn’t offer to help her this time. There’s a warm duvet and plenty of pillows, but a distinct lack of blankets, just like Adora mentioned. She hesitates at the foot of the bed, waiting for Adora to say or do something. Adora looks at her from the corner of her eye before moving two of the thicker pillows under the blankets by the end of the bed.

“That should be enough to keep your foot up.” Without another word, she climbs into the other side of the bed, facing away toward the wall.

It’s three steps to the bed and Catra makes it without stumbling. She gingerly lays down, wincing as she moves her ankle. It’s noticeable colder in the cabin already, but it’s warmer under the blanket. She can tell Adora’s awake—she’s carefully collected on one side of the bed, not sprawled like she usually is when she slumbers.

Catra turns slightly, eyes veering to the back of Adora’s head. Her shoulders are tense and Catra can’t recall the last time they slept in the same bed apart like this. It finally clicks that this is it—the snow will thaw at some point, and this will be the last time she’ll lay next to Adora.

Fuck. The tears that she’s been fighting since she walked into the cabin spring up full force. Catra bites her bottom lip to keep her sobs in and she turns so that if Adora happens to look over, she won’t see her. She wraps her arms around herself and she lets the tears run,

mourning every decision that's lead her here, cold and alone, adrift and drowning in the fact that Adora doesn't want her anymore.

Catra is ready to spend her life with Adora, fight or no. She knows that this is what she wants but what is she supposed to do now? How is she supposed to find a way to move on from Adora.

Suddenly, a loud sob breaks from her and she quickly covers her mouth. She freezes, not daring to even breathe for a moment. She feels Adora shift cautiously next to her. Catra feels the bed sink in and the warmth of Adora's hand almost brushing against her back. She doesn't feel Adora's touch—instead, Catra hears her sighs and then she shifts away again.

It takes a long time for Catra to fall asleep after that. When the sunlight starts streaming in through the slats of the windows, she wakes up, teeth chattering from the cold. She can see her breath clouding in front of her and her nose is so cold the skin around it feels tight. She burrows her nose under the covers, eyes tired from crying and her bottom lip almost split open from biting it to keep quiet.

She doesn't move until she feels the bed shift and Adora gets up, coming around and into view. Her hair looks a mess, like she'd been racking her hands through it and her eyes are redder than when she went to bed last night. Silently, she holds out a thick sweater, offering it to Catra.

She takes it wordlessly, pulling down the covers enough to pull it on over her head. She should have thought to ask for something like this last night but even if it did occur to her, she's not sure that she would have. It helps with the cold, but not by much.

Adora looks at her trembling limbs and her gaze narrows with worry. "I'm going to see if the door is open now. See if I can get some firewood."

Catra nods and watches as Adora all but rushes out of the room. She flops back onto the bed, burrowing to stay as warm as she can. She knows she should probably say something—ask Adora why she thinks they're over or anything that veers into the topic of them. But she's also terrified of what she might hear in response. Every time their eyes meet, it's like the words are clogged, rattling in Catra's chest.

She breathes a sigh of relief when she hears the door open loudly—she's guessing Adora had to put her weight behind it. It's not long until she hears Adora's sturdy boots thudding inside the cabin and then her fiddling with the fireplace.

Catra gets up, doing her best to move using the bed frame and the walls to make her way toward the small living room. Adora is down in a low squat, a small fire has already started. She's staring at the embers, moving them with a poker before leaving it alone and standing. When she looks over at Catra, she can't help but notice Adora is absolutely covered in slush, some snow in her hair.

"It's still snowing—I honestly don't know how I get the door open." She shakes her head. "I brought in a good amount of wood that I cut earlier but hadn't brought in before the snowstorm. Most of it is wet but hopefully it'll dry out in here."

“You could have gotten hurt, going out there.” Catra hadn’t realized it was still storming outside—she’d thought it would have passed overnight.

Adora’s face tenses. “We were both going to get hurt if we didn’t find a heat source. There’s no way any cars are getting up or down the road here until the snowplows come through and who knows when that’ll be.”

“Sure, but what would we have done if you had hit your head out there or got lost?” She can’t help the way her voice careens higher, louder in volume as she thinks about how risky what Adora did is. She should have asked more questions before, but she’d assumed Adora wouldn’t do anything dangerous. Stupid on her part.

“It didn’t happen, Catra. What’s the point of fighting about something that literally didn’t happen.” Her eyes flash with anger. “I did what I had to, and you should be thanking me because we can be warm now.”

“The point is that it was unsafe and maybe if we had talked about it, we could have found a different solution.” Catra’s gripping the wall with both hands now, trying not to lose her balance. “But you always go off and do what you think is best. It’s what you’re good at.”

Adora looks outraged now, taking one step then another toward Catra. Before she speaks though, her body freezes and she snaps her mouth shut.

"Adora, just say whatever is on your mind." Catra snaps, her temper getting the best of her.

Adora turns, eyes flashing. "I just don't understand how you ended here, with your twisted ankle, almost dying on my doorsteps. And we're still stuck out here, fighting." Adora is angry, the words spit out like bullets. "It's like I haven't suffered enough. So now I need to go through this again."

"I didn't—it wasn't an accident."

"Twisting your ankle?"

"No, that was definitely an accident. I meant ending up at your door." Catra sighs, feeling the cold air rush into her lungs. "I came here to see you."

Adora’s eyes look like slush themselves, blue-gray and wet as they take Catra in. "You—you what?"

"I wasn't vacationing nearby. There's no other cabin.” The truth spills out of her fast. The moment she starts, it’s like she can’t stop. “I just didn't realize the weather was going to get so bad and I fucked up my foot."

"Why—why would you come here? Why did you lie?"

"What was the alternative? Tell my girlfriend that I was climbing a stupid ass mountain to find her and apologize and beg for her back—but if she could first nurse my sprained ankle?" Catra shakes her head, cheeks warm as she looks at the wall she’s using to hold herself. It’s so pathetic and embarrassing but the truth is out there now.

"You wanted to get back together?" Adora's words are almost timid and she's suddenly so much closer.

Catra chances a glance at her. "Adora, I didn't even know we'd broken up until I came up here and you acted like you never expected to see me again."

Adora has the decency to glance down sheepishly at that. "Look, let's sit." She offers out her hand and Catra lets herself take it. Her hands are cold from the outside and all Catra wants to do is bring it up to her face, kiss Adora's hand and touch it to her cheek. It doesn't take long for Catra to settle onto the couch. Adora quickly pulls off her outer jacket and sits down, looking at down at her own hands. "I was hurt. I *am* hurt." She mumbles quietly.

"I am too." Catra freely admits. This whole thing has been awful and all she wants is to know if there's a way to bridge this distance. "What I don't understand is—I love you, Adora. I've sworn that to you for so long. Why did you think I was walking away for good that day?" She needs to know, even if this is it for them.

She doesn't look up, instead she grips her hands tighter. "You'd never walked away like that before. I didn't know what else to think." She glances up, eyes accusing as she meets Catra's. "And it's not like you reach out after."

"I needed space. And then suddenly there was so much space I wasn't sure if you wanted me to come back." Catra tries to swallow the knot in her throat. "But I needed to try."

"Then why didn't you—" Adora huffs a short laugh—it's wet, almost like a sob. "Then why didn't you try? We've been sitting in this cabin for almost a full day, and you haven't said anything."

"I'm scared." She shifts a little closer, ignoring the throb of protest from her foot. "And I fucking suck at talking about how I feel."

Adora groans, holding her hands out as if exasperated. "Well so do I! You've been acting normal and I've been beside myself. I can hardly look at you, it hurts so bad!"

"Normal?" Catra's voice hitches. "You think I'm not upset. That I haven't been crying every second I've been alone in this stupid cabin?" She feels her tears now, the ones she'd managed to hide mostly up to now. She thinks about bringing up the fact that she knows Adora heard her cry last night, but she doesn't. "Well, I'm not normal or fine. I'm miserable and all I've wanted is a chance to actually talk to you and fix things."

Adora looks away, out of the window in the little living room, the wind howling and outside just a flurry of white. When she looks back, her eyes are sad, tear streaks on her face.

"Okay." She clears her throat. "I'm going to take a minute and make some tea. Then we can talk. Do you want any?"

Catra's breath stutters. This is what they used to do—Catra would make tea for them, and they'd talk about what was wrong. Adora would tease her about it at times, but the callback

feels like an olive branch, the first glimmer of hope since she was walking through this snowstorm trying to find Adora.

"Yeah. That sounds good." She thinks of following Adora into the kitchen, but she knows the tea is for space. It's so they can center themselves and be ready to talk. Chasing Adora won't do her any good now.

She sinks into the old couch and tries to steady her breathing. This is the talk she thought she'd get when she was driving up here. It doesn't take all that long for Adora to be back, two teacups trembling in her hands.

Catra grabs the offered one, sitting down on one end of the couch while Adora takes the other. Her bad leg is hanging off the side of the couch as she faces in, toward Adora, but she barely thinks of the mild discomfort in her ankle.

They stare at each other for a moment, a mountain of throw pillows between them. Catra looks down at her teacup, the wisps of steam tickling her face. "I guess ... why don't we start at the beginning?"

"You left." For once, Adora's words don't feel like an accusation, just sad.

Catra shakes her head. "No, I didn't leave. I needed space."

"Three weeks of space is a hell of a long time."

"I didn't need that much space, but can you blame me if I had?" Catra looks down at her hands clenched around one of the pillows. "You said I was being too clingy and asking for too much when I wanted you to consider switching to a local hospital. You left for however long you had work, and I didn't hear a word from you—I thought you didn't want to hear from me."

"But you walked out of our fight. You just said you were done." Adora's voice has a tremble to it that makes Catra deflate. "I thought you would reach out and you didn't. What was I supposed to think?"

Hearing the doubt flooding Adora's voice, she can tell that Adora means it. And she's right—Catra should have thought that she'd need to make the first move for reconciliation, and she bungled that up. "I'm sorry about the way I asked for space. It wasn't right—I don't have an excuse." Catra swallows thickly. "But I didn't, not for one moment think you'd take that as done with *us*. That's not what I meant at all. I was done with the fight, and frankly this argument we keep having about your job—but not you, Adora." She bites her lip. "I don't think I could ever be done with you."

"You can't just say that." Adora's crying openly now, her head in her hands. She peeks out form behind them, an almost pout on her lips. The look verges on playful and it feels almost normal.

"Why not?"

"It's really sweet." She complains.

Catra lets out an unexpected chuckle. "What am I supposed to say then?"

"Something real asshole-ish so I can leave you for dead in an ice cube outside and I won't feel bad about it." It's a flippant remark but it makes Catra sober some.

"Is that really what you want?" If Adora just wants an excuse to make sure they don't get back together, then there isn't much Catra can do—she loves Adora, but she only wants to be with her if Adora wants her back. She can't stand the thought of begging for her affection. Catra doesn't have it in her.

She hears Adora's sigh. "No. I don't want to fight anymore, and I want to be with you." Adora's eyes look up at Catra, vulnerable and soft. "But I don't think I can stand another fight like that."

Catra nods. "I didn't like that either." She thinks of how to frame her question. "So, I get that the way I left that night was bad. Is the problem that I asked for space or how I did it? Anything else you didn't like?"

She looks out at the crackling fire. The small fire is roaring now, and the warmth makes the living room only slightly nippy. "I can't deal with you leaving and not saying when you're coming back. And I don't want to have a fight where you storm off so angry. Even if it's just a minute to tell me that you need space." Adora sniffles pulling a pillow into her chest. "I waited until the last minute to leave for my job, hoping you'd come back."

The thought of Adora waiting on her hadn't really occurred to Catra. "Fuck. I'm sorry. I didn't come back the next day because I didn't want to have another fight right before you left. I thought we could talk after you came back and we could figure it out." She sighs, looking up at Adora. "I can work on all that." She promises.

In truth, those were all the things she'd been working on. It had been a long time since they'd fallen into old habits like that. They'd both been under a lot of stress and snapped in the worst way. Catra thought that it was just that—ugly, but manageable. Clearly, there was more to it.

"Okay." Adora sighs, looking away. "Was there anything for you that you think I could have done differently."

She looks away for a moment, collecting her thoughts. "I didn't feel listened to." She says carefully. "Every time I tried to tell you how I felt, I was dismissed. You're usually good about hearing me out but when it comes to work it's like nothing I say sinks in." She takes a deep breath through her nose. "And even if it's what I'm being—I *hate* being called clingy. It just—it hits all the wrong buttons, especially when we're already in the middle of an argument."

Adora knows how Catra feels—knows that she has abandonment issues a mile wide regardless of what therapy has done for her. Knows that underneath it all, some part of Catra feels unlovable—the same part that screams at her for trying to hold on too tightly to everything good in her life, lest she strangle it.

It's quiet for so long that Catra thinks Adora isn't listening *again*. Instead, when she looks up, Adora's eyes are focused solely on her. She reaches her hand out and for the first time since Catra arrived, their hands touch for no other reason than comfort.

"I'm sorry. I never want to make you feel like that. I wasn't thinking when I said it—I honestly hadn't realized that's a word I used that day."

She's not sure if she expected an apology from Adora but she feels her shoulders drop. She squeezes Adora's hand and nods. "It's okay." It still stings even all this time after, but she believes Adora when she says it was an act of carelessness and not malice.

Adora's looking down at their joined hands. Throughout the conversation, she's gotten closer, almost pressed to Catra's side. "So, if you never thought we were broken up then … you want to stay together?" The words are soft, whispered in Catra's ear. Almost like she's afraid of the answer.

She leans into Adora, close enough that they are cheek to cheek. Not looking at each other, but close enough that she can hear the way Adora's breath stutters. "Of course I want to." It's never been a question of commitment—from the moment they'd confessed love for each other, Catra knew that Adora was who she wanted to spend her life with.

Adora nuzzles her neck, dropping a tentative kiss there. "I love you."

Her hand cups Catra's face, fingers gently tilting her chin so that they are eye to eye. They press their foreheads together and just breathe. Something loosens in Catra's chest—relief, joy, *love*—but she doesn't move an inch from where she is. She just soaks up Adora's closeness, the relief she can feel radiating off her too.

When Adora backs up, there's a soft smile on her face. "Want to go back to the bedroom for a bit and then I can figure out breakfast?" There's a hopeful tilt to her brow that's almost irresistible.

Catra bites her lip, considering Adora. There's nothing she'd like more than to treat the last few weeks like water under the bridge. She's sure that they'd hold each other close—as close as her hurt ankle will allow—and it'll feel so good to be wrapped up in Adora. Healing, even.

What is niggling at the back of Catra's mind is that it *isn't* water under the bridge. "That all sounds great, but we haven't solved what we were originally fighting about." She can't help but point out. "I think we should talk about it."

She doesn't want to break the fragile peace between them, but she knows if they bury now, there's no chance they'll address it before it rears its ugly head again.

Adora sighs, but nods. "You're right." She pulls her hand back from Catra's and holds them together nervously—it hurts, even though she knows Adora doesn't mean it as a rejection. She turns her body so that she can look at Catra full on. "With how unstable everything has been between us, I'm even more hesitant to switch jobs if I'm honest." She blurts it out, eyes pleading with Catra to understand.

"That's fair, I guess." Catra feels her eyes filling up with tears, old feelings of abandonment and rejection rising to the surface quickly. "Is it so bad, though? That I want you around? I get that even if you're working at a local hospital we won't necessarily be together every night, but don't you miss me?"

Her face softens. "Of course, I miss you." Adora shakes her head. "All I do is think about you and miss you. I don't like that work takes me from you but it's so much more money and I love it."

"I just want a timeline. I get it if that isn't on the table right now, but I want some reassurance that this isn't going to be my whole life—just missing you for weeks on end forever." Adora being away for so long really rubs her raw in some of her biggest insecurities—and that's on top of how much she just *missed* Adora.

"I was planning on another year." Adora looks almost bashful, before peeking up at Catra. "I thought that maybe by then, we'd be in a different place."

The loaded way that Adora says it makes Catra raise an eyebrow. "What does that mean?"

She glances away, her hand teasing the edge of the pillow in her lap. "You know ... more serious. *Settled*."

Catra's eyes widen. "Are we not settled? Or were we not before all this?" She thought of them as settled as settled could be.

"Well, yeah. But you know." Adora shrugs, her expression somewhat pinched. "Marriage. A house, maybe." She floats the ideas like they are novel.

Catra blinks at her. The surprise she feels cuts through the embarrassment and makes her bluntly honest. "Adora, I was going to ask you to marry me next month."

"You—what?" Adora's eyes are so wide, you'd think her eyeballs would fall right out of the sockets.

"That's part of why I was so on edge that day. I'd been getting the damn ring resized at the jewelry store and it just reminded me of all the things that we still needed to talk about and I just ... lost control of it all." The fight spiraled so quickly and there felt like there was so much pressure—she wanted to sort things out so that she could finally have what she wanted. Instead, she pushed Adora away and almost ended them.

"Wow. I had no idea."

"Yeah, I gather that now." It hurts her stomach to think that Adora is so surprised by her intentions. She thought that they'd had conversations leading in the direction. And she supposes they did—they were just thinking of different timeframes.

"You still have a ring?" The question is soft, Adora reaching out again to brush her fingers along Catra's arm.

"Of course, I do." Catra swallows the lump in her throat. "I thought we were fighting, not over. Why would I get rid of it?" She knew that whatever plans she had, they'd likely have to be postponed. Catra wasn't really intending on telling Adora that she was planning on proposing, it just sort of slipped out. "Not that I'm going to ask given." She waves her hand in the air. "All this."

Adora nods, although she surprisingly looks a bit put out. It's quiet for a minute while they stare at the fireplace for a moment. The fire is dying down some but it's still warm.

Adora makes a little noise in the back of her throat before quirking an eyebrow. "So, you just thought I was ignoring you for three weeks?"

She feels a rush of embarrassment at the incredulous look on her girlfriend's face. She can admit that it wasn't her brightest moment—and maybe some part of her wanted Adora to reach out first. To show that she would choose Catra. "When you say it like that, I feel kind of silly."

"It was a little silly." Their eyes catch and Adora gives her a smile, tentative and soft.

"I just—I need a bit more, Adora." Catra shrugs helplessly. She wishes it weren't the case, but she can't deny it any longer. "I'm willing to compromise and work on our relationship, but I can't do you being gone forever."

Instead of responding right away, Adora closes her eyes, takes a deep breath and then looks at Catra. "I'm sorry I was stubborn about it. I know you aren't attacking me but I just—I love my work and I like feeling like I'm paid what I'm worth. And people need me at these underserved hospitals—they need nurses willing to go where they're needed." She bites her lip. "When you insist on me changing jobs like you did—like it means nothing—it makes me feel like you don't appreciate what I do."

"I'm glad that you love your job and that you help people." Catra really does—she knows that Adora has a big heart, that she pours all of herself into her work. That she saves lives as a result. Still, Catra feels a lump in her throat. "I just want you to love me too."

Adora reaches out with both hands, grabbing one of Catra's and placing a soft kiss on it. "I do love you, Catra. Don't you feel that?"

"I do most of the time. I miss you when you're gone though." Catra has always known who Adora is—selfless to a fault, her life dedicated to saving people. "I don't need you to give up your dreams, 'Dor. I just want you to dream with me too."

Adora nods slowly, lips downturned in a frown. "Okay." She reaches out, grabbing Catra's hand. "I'm not going to switch jobs right now, but maybe in six months we can check in? And I can take only jobs with block scheduling. Would it help if I was home for two nights a week at least?"

She ignores the way Adora says home for a moment, even though it threatens to both warm her and tie her stomach in knots. "Don't you hate working all those days back-to-back?"

Part of the reasons that Adora hasn't been able to come home as often is because she prefers a traditional schedule instead of a block schedule where she could work all her days in a row. Even with a block schedule, some of the hospitals are simply too far for Adora to toggle back and forth.

She shrugs. "Compromise, right?" Adora squeezes Catra's hand, her thumb rubbing along Catra's knuckles. "I—it's my job to make you feel loved. It would be an adjustment but if it makes us work, then that'll be good for me."

"You sure?" Catra doesn't want to get her hopes up and she also feels conflicted—as much as she wants Adora's job to better accommodate her, she also doesn't want her girlfriend to feel like she's missing out.

Adora nods, leaning forward so their foreheads are pressed together. "What if we just feel things out some? Next contract, I'll make sure I do block scheduling and we will take it from there." She proposes.

Catra nods letting her hand move up into Adora's hair. "Hey … does it feel way too warm right now?"

Adora looks around, eyes widening as she looks at something behind Catra. "Those blankets were not there before!" She turns back and sees a neatly stacked pile of blankets. Adora tugs her hand. "Right? You hadn't seen them either?" She hears the doubt creeping in Adora's voice.

"Absolutely not. Those were not there." Catra hears something else, a humming she hadn't noticed as deep as they were in their conversation. "Is the radiator on?"

"Shit, yeah." Adora turns back to look at her. "No wonder it's warm."

Something else catches her eye as she looks around the room cataloguing any other differences. "Is that a mistletoe?" The greenery is perched right above the couch. Catra thinks she would have noticed that last night, even in her distraught state.

Of all things, that is what makes Adora go beet red. "I swear I didn't put it up."

"I somehow believe that." Between all the oddities of the last few minutes, Catra doesn't doubt anything. She also doesn't want to think about it too hard. She bites her lip, letting a hand tentatively move up onto Adora's shoulder. "Means it's a magical mistletoe, though. We should probably listen to it."

"Yeah?" Adora looks amused, her eyes tender as she takes Catra in.

She shrugs one shoulder casually, as if she isn't dying to kiss Adora. "If you want to."

Adora leans closer pressing her forehead to Catra's. For a moment, she thinks Adora is going to kiss her before she pulls back, eyeing her. "I need you to be serious about staying together, because I never want to go through this again."

She nods solemnly. "I swear, Adora. I'm sorry I hurt you." Catra knows this probably isn't the last conversation they'll need to have to unpack their fight and the ongoing struggle of Adora's work-life balance, but it feels like a solid start. Like something she can rely on.

"I'm sorry too." Adora offers back.

She tugs Adora down until their lips meet and she can't help the groan that escapes her lips. Adora kisses her back with enthusiasm, her lips everywhere at once, kissing her lips, her cheeks, down her neck and back. Catra lets her hands travel over her girlfriend, feeling her and truly appreciating it for the first time since their fight.

Fuck, Adora is so soft and strong, gorgeous under her lips and her hands—gorgeous inside and out. Catra leans forward with a little too much gusto and then she hisses, breaking the kiss when she accidentally puts some weight on her bad leg.

Adora holds her close, eyes wandering Catra's face with concern. Her eyes flicker down to her leg and Adora's face colors with understanding. She leans in and places a soft, sweet kiss on Catra's lips.

"I'm going to rewrap your ankle and get us food. Then we can see about getting out of this cabin." Adora promises, still lingering close to Catra.

It serves her just fine. "I'm not as concerned with leaving now." She admits softly, her hands wrapping around Adora's neck.

Adora nods softly. "We'll figure it all out." She promises. Catra can't tell if she's talking about getting back home or everything between them, but she knows Adora is right either way.

End Notes

IDK that we needed this much angst this holiday season but here we are! This is for the_deaf_pomegranate. You are a phenomenal writer and an even better friend. I hope that you liked it and that you have a great holiday season!

Kudos and comments make me happy. I'm on Twitter, Bluesky, and Tumblr.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!